



The Friend I Did Not Lose

Student copy (project or hand out)

1 There is a contact in my phone I have not called in four years, and I scrolled past her name this morning the way you step around a chair you keep meaning to move. We used to talk three times a week. Now I could not tell you the city she lives in without guessing, and I would guess wrong.

2 I want to be careful with the word lose, because it is the one everyone reaches for and it is wrong. Nobody took her. We did not fight. There was no last conversation that anyone would recognize as a last one, no door, no slam, just a slow widening of the kind the research describes: shared activity, nearness, and steady contact hold a friendship up, and when those go, the bond does not break so much as quietly thin (Rawlins, 1992; Rose and Serafica, 1986). She moved for a job. I had a kid. Competing demands did the rest (Rohlfing, 1995).

3 A dorm hallway is exactly the kind of place these friendships tend to start and exactly the kind of bond that tends to thin once the place that made it is gone (Blieszner and Adams, 1992; Carbery and Buhrmester, 1998). I did not know that at nineteen. Being known like that feels permanent, like a thing you own rather than a thing you are standing inside of for a while. I owned nothing. I was a guest in a season of her life and she in mine.

4 Here is what took me a decade to believe. Your circle of friends actually shrinks in your thirties and forties, and that shrinking is not coldness but a sorting, the mind spending less time on more meaning as the runway ahead gets shorter (Carstensen, 1992). I have fewer friends now. The ones I have, I would drive through the night for. She is not one of them anymore, and both of those sentences are true.

5 Because it was grief. The strange kind, the kind nobody brings a casserole for, with no real ritual to mark it (Felmlee and Muraco, 2009). My grandmother kept buttons in a tin that smelled like pennies. Grief over a person who is alive and well is a quieter thing, and quieter does not mean smaller.

6 So I have stopped saying I lost her. What I mean is that the friendship finished, the way a good book finishes. Letting the distance be what it was, instead of forcing contact to fight it, is what keeps the memory of her good and keeps the resentment out (Rachuy, 2011; Adams and Blieszner, 1994). She was a real part of one stretch of my life.

7 I do not need her back. I need to have been her friend, which already happened, which nothing now can undo. The tin is still in a drawer somewhere. I keep meaning to find it.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the second paragraph, the writer insists on rejecting the word lose primarily to
 - A) accuse the friend of having abandoned the relationship without explanation
 - B) reframe the ending of the friendship as a gradual thinning rather than a loss someone caused
 - C) prove that most adult friendships are destroyed by a single decisive argument
 - D) argue that the word lose should never be used about people who are still alive
2. In context, the closing image of the tin the writer keeps meaning to find best supports which characterization of the writer's tone?
 - A) detached indifference toward a relationship the writer no longer cares about
 - B) settled acceptance that values what the friendship was without needing to act on it now
 - C) wistful regret that the writer failed to keep the friendship alive
 - D) anxious urgency to recover something before it is lost for good

Discussion questions:

1. The writer spends the whole piece refusing the word lose and proposing other words for it (finished, thinned, a season). Which substitute best fits what the passage actually describes, and what does each word ask the reader to feel that the others do not?
2. The narrator says two sentences can both be true: that the friend is no longer close, and that the writer would drive through the night for the friends who remain. How does the piece earn the right to hold two feelings at once instead of resolving into either nostalgia or bitterness?

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q2 rhetorical analysis):

The following passage is a first-person reflection on the quiet ending of a long friendship. Read the passage carefully. Then write an essay that analyzes the rhetorical choices the writer makes to develop a reframing of what it means to lose a friend. In your response you should do the following: respond to the prompt with a defensible thesis that analyzes the writer's rhetorical choices; select and use evidence to support your line of reasoning; explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning; and demonstrate an understanding of the rhetorical situation. Consider how the writer's diction (especially the contested word lose), figurative language, sentence structure, and use of concrete personal detail work together to move the reader from the language of breakage toward the language of completion.